

Friends Turn FOES

While Naveen Patnaik gambles on going it alone, his ally-turned-foe BJP is spewing venom on him, leaving the Congress waiting to pick up the pieces



IN GOING IT ALONE, NAVEEN (CENTRE) MAY HAVE STRUNG A NOOSE FOR HIMSELF

Photographs by GIRDHARI LAL SARANGI

By Farzand Ahmed |

He cuts a lonely figure, does Naveen Patnaik, Orissa chief minister and Biju Janata Dal (BJD) chief, as he braves 42-degree heat in the Koraput region. Unlike other star campaigners and regional chieftains, he sits alone on the dais apart

from the local candidate. April is a cruel month and his helicopter-hopping is an energy-draining exercise. Despite that, he is his usual unruffled self, laid-back and low-key, addressing the tribal audience as if they were a group of schoolchildren and he their teacher. Yet, there are some hard lessons he has learnt himself, not the last being the position he has put himself

in, facing a sustained attack by his former ally, the BJP, stung and smarting at his "betrayal". Naveen's task is unenviable. He is, by nature, not an aggressive speaker, and having to take on the BJP and the Congress has made him somewhat desperate, a man who, despite his outward show of confidence, has his back to the wall.

At meeting after meeting, his mes-